the Jammu and Kashmir force and joined the Indian army's operations in Kashmir. The former princely state had been invaded in October 1947 by tribal raiders from the newly created Pakistan. Thimayya's daring tactics helped the army successfully push the raiders back despite the punishing terrain and extreme cold. His successful exploits in Kashmir made him a household name.



One of Thimayya's best-known operations in Kashmir was an audacious tank assault on Zojila, a high mountain pass that linked Ladakh to Kashmir. It was the highest altitude at which tanks had ever been deployed, and they decisively tilted the balance in India's favour, and allowed Ladakh to remain protected.

Man of the world

Over the years, Thimayya gained the reputation of being an excellent soldier but also a man of great personal charm and diplomacy. He represented India internationally on several occasions, notably at the UN during attempts to settle the Kashmir conflict, and as chairman of the Neutral Nations Repatriation Commission in Korea in 1953. The latter was a complex job, and his efforts to be rigorously impartial brought him international acclaim. In 1964, Thimayya was asked to head the UN Peacekeeping Force in Cyprus. He died on duty at the age of fifty-nine.